Lingji Yang

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RESEARCH PROFILE

Media and communication researcher focusing on human–AI interaction, AI-mediated self-reflection, user agency, and social connection. Empirical experience in netnography, in-depth interviews, phenomenological analysis, and structured platform data collection. Training in experimental design, causal inference, and simulation-based statistical analysis in R. Interested in evaluating how conversational agents and engaging technologies support reflection, participation, and wellbeing.

EDUCATION

Uppsala University - **MSc in Digital Media and Society（English-medium programme)** Sep 2024 - Oct 2026

- Master's Thesis (30 ECTS): Digital Transgression: Chinese Women's Kink Interactions with Generative AI.
- Relevant coursework: Forecasting Methods and Causal Inference for the Social Sciences (VG); Qualitative Methods in the Social Sciences (VG); Health Psychology and Behavioural Medicine (VG); Quantitative Methods (G).
- Awarded Pass with Distinction (VG) in eight courses.

Sichuan University of Media and Communications - **BA in Network and New Media** Sep 2018 - Jun 2022

- **GPA:** 85.1/100 (top 3% of the major)
- **Outstanding Graduate**
- **Second Class Scholarship at the University level (2019, 2021)**

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Master's Thesis Researcher | Uppsala University, Sweden Jan 2026 - Oct 2026

Digital Transgression: Chinese Women's Kink Interactions with Generative AI

- Independently designed and conducted a qualitative study combining netnographic observation with two rounds of in-depth interviews involving nine Chinese women (18 interviews in total).
- Applied existential phenomenological research methods, including meaning-unit analysis, individual structural descriptions, and cross-case synthesis, to investigate user agency, self-understanding, and AI-mediated experiences.
- Developed a digital transgression analytical framework integrating existential media theory and theories of erotic transgression to examine how generative AI mediates vulnerability, control, and personal boundaries.
- Addressed ethical challenges involving sensitive digital practices, informed consent, participant anonymity, and the interpretation of private disclosures.

Research Intern | Uppsala University, Sweden Sep 2025 - Nov 2025

Intimate AI: Young Women's Self-Perception and Embodied Knowledge in Times of Automation

- Conducted netnographic research on women's generative AI persona practices and intimate role-playing communities on Xiaohongshu (RedNote).
- Collected and organized empirical material into five interconnected datasets covering platform metadata, persona scripts, word-frequency statistics, AI constraint rules, and user discussions.
- Developed a core corpus of 27 posts from 25 creators and 45 classifiable comments for systematic analysis.
- Applied qualitative coding and descriptive textual analysis to examine user agency, collaborative prompt development, and the negotiation of AI-generated responses.

SELECTED RESEARCH PROJECTS

Affective vs Cognitive AI in Digital Intimacy - A Pre-Analysis Plan

Forecasting Methods and Causal Inference for the Social Sciences | 2025

- Designed a proposed 14-day randomized between-subjects experiment examining the effects of supportive versus critical chatbot responses on self-disclosure, trust, and perceived intimacy.
- Operationalized psychological mediators and attachment-style moderators to examine potential mechanisms and heterogeneous treatment effects.
- Adapted and executed course-provided R scripts for simulation-based analyses involving OLS regression, bootstrapped mediation analysis, and causal forests.

Between Healing and Harm - A Dual-Pathway–Three-Dimension Model of Digital Companionship and Mental Health

Health Psychology and Behavioural Medicine | Spring 2025

- Conducted a scoping review synthesizing 21 selected studies on the psychological benefits and risks of AI companionship.
- Applied matrix-based thematic analysis to identify compensatory and potentially depleting pathways associated with digital companionship.
- Developed an interdisciplinary conceptual model integrating psychological flexibility, emotional compensation, and social skill depletion.

ADDITIONAL PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Integrated Media Centre Specialist - Beijing Normal University, China Apr 2020 - Jun 2022

Academy for International Communication of Chinese Culture | Looking China International Youth Film Project

- Developed cross-platform communication materials, contributed to exhibition and programme coordination, and supported audience engagement analysis.

Assistant - Chongqing Tongliang Integrated Media Centre, China Jun 2019 - Sep 2019

Breaking Dawn – The Secret Archives of Chongqing Liberation (National Key Documentary Selection, 2019)

- Supported documentary research through archival collection, scripting support, and factual verification.

Cultural Programme and Communications Assistant - China Cultural Center in Stockholm Aug 2026 - Oct 2026

- Supported cultural exhibitions, film screenings, and public programmes, including China Film Week and the Yongle Palace Mural Art Exhibition; produced bilingual social media content and assisted with visitor engagement and event coordination.

RESEARCH SKILLS

Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native); English (Academic working proficiency)
Qualitative Research: In-depth interviewing; netnography; existential phenomenological analysis; meaning-unit analysis; cross-case synthesis; qualitative content analysis; thematic analysis.
Quantitative Research: Experimental design; variable operationalization; simulation-based statistical analysis; foundational causal inference; introductory regression and mediation analysis; exposure to causal forests through adapted instructional code.
Data Collection & Research Synthesis: Structured digital data collection; platform content coding; descriptive textual analysis; scoping reviews; narrative literature reviews; research ethics and participant anonymization.
Software: R/RStudio (adaptation and execution of existing analytical scripts); Jamovi; NVivo; Microsoft Excel.